

These idioms, known as “chengyu” (成语), are an integral part of the Chinese language, offering a glimpse into Chinese culture and history. These idioms, typically composed of four Chinese characters, often derive from ancient literature, historical events, or philosophical musings, encapsulating profound wisdom and cultural values in just a few words.

For learners, understanding these idioms is essential for mastering the language and appreciating the depth and nuance of Chinese expression. Each Chinese chengyu conveys complex ideas and vivid imagery, making the language rich and dynamic.

Its blend of literal and figurative meanings makes a Chinese idiom particularly unique. For example, the idiom “yī jiàn shuāng diào” (一箭双雕), which translates to “one arrow, two golden eagles,” is like the English phrase “kill two birds with one stone.” By learning these idioms, one can gain insights into ancient Chinese literature and the lives and thoughts of Chinese people from centuries ago.

What are Chinese idioms (chengyu)?

Chinese idioms originate back to ancient myths, legends, and historical events. These idioms are deeply rooted in classical literature and history, often reflecting the wisdom and philosophies of ancient China.

Many chengyu come from famous historical texts, ancient poetry, or well-known Chinese proverbs. For example, “wò hǔ cáng lóng” (卧虎藏龙), which literally means “crouching tiger, hidden dragon,” describes a situation where hidden talents or dangerous elements are not immediately apparent. Learning these popular Chinese idioms enhances one's Chinese vocabulary and provides insights into Chinese culture and history, enriching the understanding of the language and its speakers.

Most common Chinese idioms typically consist of four characters. These idioms are concise and often employ figurative language, making them rich in meaning and cultural significance. Each chengyu conveys a complex idea or moral, often with a story or historical event behind it. For example, the idiom “yī jiàn shuāng diào” (一箭双雕), which translates to “one arrow, two golden eagles,” is used to describe achieving two goals with a single effort, similar to the English idiom “kill two birds with one stone.”

Why are Chinese Idioms Important?

Chinese idiom hold significant importance in the Chinese language and culture as they hold deep meanings of wisdom and history. Mastering many Chinese idioms is essential for achieving cultural fluency, as they are deeply embedded in literature, conversation, and thought processes.

The benefits of learning Chinese idioms extend beyond cultural understanding. Enhanced communication is one key advantage, as chengyu are commonly used by Chinese speakers in everyday conversation to convey complex ideas succinctly. This skill can significantly improve one's ability to engage in meaningful dialogue and understand the subtleties of spoken and written Chinese.

Moreover, learning Chinese idioms sharpens thinking by encouraging individuals to think metaphorically and contextually. The figurative meaning of many chengyu often stems from ancient myths, historical events, or philosophical musings, requiring learners to connect abstract concepts with concrete expressions.

Different Types of Chinese Idioms

Chinese idioms, or “chengyu” (成语), come in various forms, each offering unique insights into Chinese language and culture. Here are some of the most common types of Chinese idioms:

Historical Idioms (历史成语): These idioms originate from specific historical events or figures. They often encapsulate the essence of a significant occurrence in Chinese history.

- Example: “四面楚歌” (sì miàn chǔ gē) – “Besieged on all sides” originates from the defeat of Xiang Yu in the Chu-Han Contention.

Mythological Idioms (神话成语): Derived from ancient myths and legends, these idioms reflect the rich tapestry of Chinese folklore and fairy tales.

- Example: “画龙点睛” (huà lóng diǎn jīng) – “Adding the finishing touch” comes from a legend about a painter who added eyes to a dragon, bringing it to life.

Philosophical Idioms (哲理成语): Rooted in classical Chinese philosophy, these idioms convey deep moral or philosophical meanings, often used to impart wisdom.

- Example: “塞翁失马” (sài wēng shī mǎ) – “A blessing in disguise” originates from a parable about an old man whose loss turned out to be a gain.

Proverbial Idioms (谚语成语): Similar to proverbs, these idioms provide practical advice or observations about life, often encapsulating common wisdom.

- Example: “井底之蛙” (jǐng dǐ zhī wā) – “A frog in a well” is used to describe someone with a limited perspective.

Descriptive Idioms (描写成语): These idioms are used to vividly describe people, situations, or objects, often enhancing the expressiveness of language.

- Example: “虎头蛇尾” (hǔ tóu shé wěi) – “Tiger's head, snake's tail” describes something that starts strong but ends weakly.

Humorous Idioms (幽默成语): Featuring wordplay or humorous elements, these idioms add a light-hearted touch to language.

- Example: “对牛弹琴” (duì niú tán qín) – “Playing the lute to a cow” means explaining something to someone who cannot understand.

Exaggerated Idioms (夸张成语): These idioms use hyperbole to emphasise a point or describe something exaggeratedly.

- Example: “一箭双雕” (yī jiàn shuāng diào) – “One arrow, two golden eagles” means achieving two things with one action.

Literal Translation Idioms (直译成语): Some idioms are directly translated from classical Chinese into modern Chinese, maintaining their original structure and meaning.

- Example: “一石二鸟” (yī shí èr niǎo) – “One stone, two birds,” similar to the English “kill two birds with one stone.”

Chengyu (four-character idioms)

“Chengyu” (成语) is the most common type of Chinese idiom, typically consisting of four Chinese characters that convey a concise and profound meaning. These idioms are deeply embedded in Chinese culture and essential to the Chinese language. Chengyu often originates from classical Chinese literature, historical events, ancient myths, and philosophical musings, encapsulating complex ideas and cultural wisdom in just a few words.

Mastering chengyu is crucial for achieving fluency and cultural understanding for Chinese learners. These idioms are frequently used in written and spoken Chinese to succinctly and vividly convey ideas. For example, the idiom “yī jiàn shuāng diào” (一箭双雕), which translates to “one arrow, two golden eagles,” is used to describe achieving two goals with a single action, similar to the English expression “kill two birds with one stone.”

Chengyu enhances Chinese vocabulary by providing figurative meanings that enrich everyday conversation and written expression.

Guyu (ancient sayings)

“Guyu” (古语) refers to sayings originating from ancient China, often with a simpler structure than chengyu” but still holding significant historical and cultural importance. Unlike chengyu, which typically consists of four character phrases, guyu can vary in length and complexity, yet they convey wisdom, moral lessons, and insights from ancient Chinese literature, myths, and history. These ancient sayings are integral to the Chinese language and culture, reflecting ancient China's values and philosophical musings.

Guyu provides valuable context and enriches the understanding of Chinese idioms and proverbs. They are frequently used in both classical and modern Chinese to express common wisdom and cultural heritage. For Chinese learners, familiarising oneself with guyu is beneficial for deepening cultural fluency and enhancing vocabulary. These sayings are often used to describe situations or convey figurative meanings, making them essential to effective communication in Chinese.

Xianyu (proverbs)

“Xianyu” (谚语) are proverbs in the Chinese language, similar to those found in other cultures, that often focus on practical wisdom and everyday life lessons. These proverbs are an integral part of Chinese culture, reflecting the common sense, values, and experiences of the Chinese people throughout history.

Xianyu are concise expressions that convey timeless truths and advice, often derived from classical Chinese literature, historical events, and ancient myths. For instance, the proverb “三人行，必有我师” (sān rén xíng, bì yǒu wǒ shī) translates to “When three people walk together, there must be one who can be my teacher,” highlighting the importance of learning from others in everyday life.

Learning Chinese proverbs like xianyu is essential for understanding the symbolic meanings behind many common Chinese idioms and expressions. These proverbs enrich Chinese vocabulary and provide deeper insights into Chinese literature and history. Native Chinese speakers widely use them in spoken and written conversations, making them valuable for effective communication.

Kouyu (spoken language idioms)

“Kouyu” (口语) refers to idioms commonly used in spoken language, often more informal than the traditional “chengyu” (成语) and reflecting modern slang or colloquialisms. These idioms are essential to everyday Chinese conversation, helping convey ideas and emotions more vividly and naturally.

Unlike the more classical and concise four-character structure of chengyu, kouyu idioms can vary in length and form, making them more flexible and adaptive to contemporary speech. They often emerge from popular culture, social trends, or local dialects, capturing the dynamic and evolving nature of the Chinese language.

Learning kouyu idioms is crucial for achieving fluency in Chinese, as they are frequently used by native speakers in casual conversations. These idioms help learners understand the nuances of modern Chinese expressions and engage more effectively with Chinese speakers. For instance, the idiom “给力” (gěi lì), which literally means “give strength,” is a modern slang expression used to describe something impressive or awesome.

30 Common Chinese Idioms

Here are some of the most common Chinese idioms and their literal translation and literal meaning:

Idiom	Pinyin	Literat Translation	Meaning
一箭两得	yī jiǎn liǎng dé	One throw, two gains	Achieve two goals with one action
勤能补拙	qín néng bǔ zhuō	Diligence can make up for lack of talent	Hard work can compensate for lack of ability
滴水穿石	dī shuǐ chuān shí	Dripping water wears through stone	Persistence leads to success

亡羊补牢	wáng yáng bǔ láo	Mending the sheepfold after the sheep are lost	Better to prevent problems than fix them
盲人摸象	mǎng rén mō xiàng	A blind man feels the elephant	Having a partial understanding
早起鸟儿有虫吃	zǎo qǐ niǎo ér yǒu chóng chī	The early bird gets the worm	Be punctual and seize opportunities
慢工出细活	màn gōng chū xì huó	Slow work produces fine work	Take your time for better results

坚持到底	jiān chí dào dǐ	Persevere to the end	Don't give up, even when things are difficult
功夫不负有心人	gōng fu bù fù yǒu xīn rén	No pains, no gains	Hard work pays off
勤俭节约	qín jiǎn jié yuē	Be frugal and hardworking	Live simply and work hard
物以类聚	wù yǐ lèi jù	Birds of a feather flock together	People with similar interests find each other

礼尚往来	lǐ shàng wǎng lái	Courtesy demands reciprocity	Give and take in relationships
知己好友	zhī jǐ hǎo yǒu	Close friend, confidant	Someone who understands you deeply
海纳百川	hǎi nèi bǎi chuān	Tolerant and all-encompassing	Open-minded and accepting
滴水之恩，涌泉相报	dī shuǐ zhī ēn, yǒng quán xiāng bào	A kindness deserves a great return	Reciprocate kindness generously

实事求是	shí shì qiú shì	Seek truth from facts	Be realistic and objective
百尺竿头，更进一步	bǎi chǐ gān tóu, gèng jìn yí bù	Always room for improvement	Never stop striving to be better
兢兢业业	jīng jīng yè yè	Conscientious and dedicated	Work diligently and responsibly
独当一面	dú dāng yí miàn	Capable of handling things alone	Independent and competent

一言既出，驷马难追	yī yán jì chū, sì mǎ nán zhuī	A promise is a promise	Keep your word
喜气洋洋	xǐ qì yáng yáng	Overjoyed and jubilant	Extremely happy and excited
心灰意冷	xīn huī yì lěng	Discouraged and disheartened	Lose hope and motivation
哑巴吃黄连	yǎ ba chī huáng lián	Suffer in silence	Have a problem nobody understands

心急如焚	xīn jí rú fén	Anxious and impatient	Burning with anxiety
愁眉苦脸	chóu méi kǔ liǎn	Gloomy and downcast	Looking sad and worried
一帆风顺	yí fān fēng shùn	Smooth sailing	Everything goes well without obstacles
天有不测风云	tiān yǒu bù cè fēng yún	Life is unpredictable	Unexpected things can happen

沧海一粟	cāng hǎi yí sù	A drop in the ocean	Something insignificant compared to the whole
逆水行舟	nǐ shuǐ xíng zhōu	Going against the current	Facing challenges and difficulties
画蛇添足	huà shé tiān zú	Drawing a snake and adding legs	Ruining something by adding unnecessary details

Learn Chinese Idioms by category

Learning by category can enhance your understanding of the Chinese language and culture. Categorising idioms allows for a more structured approach, making remembering and applying them in different contexts easier.

Chinese Idioms About Life

Here are five Chinese idioms about life, emphasising hard work, diligence, overcoming challenges, good character, moral behaviour, and social harmony:

勤能补拙 (qín néng bǔ zhuō)

- Meaning: Diligence can compensate for lack of talent.
- Explanation: This idiom encourages hard work and perseverance. It implies that one can compensate for natural talent or ability deficiencies through continuous effort and diligence.

卧薪尝胆 (wò xīn cháng dǎn)

- Meaning: To sleep on brushwood and taste gall—referring to enduring hardship to achieve a goal.
- Explanation: Originating from a historical story, this idiom underscores the determination to endure hardships and overcome challenges to succeed.

志在四方 (zhì zài sì fāng)

- Meaning: Aspire to do great things and contribute in many directions.
- Explanation: It encourages setting ambitious goals and aspirations to contribute significantly to various aspects of life or society.

仰事俯畜 (yǎng shì fǔ xù)

- Meaning: To respect one's superiors and show kindness to inferiors.
- Explanation: This idiom emphasises the importance of good character and social harmony. It suggests maintaining respectful and benevolent attitudes towards people of higher and lower status.

言而有信 (yán ér yǒu xìn)

- Meaning: To keep one's promise; to be true to one's word.
- Explanation: This idiom highlights the value of integrity and trustworthiness. It stresses the importance of fulfilling promises and maintaining credibility in interpersonal relationships.

About Relationships & Social Interaction

Here are five Chinese idioms about relationships and social interaction:

推心置腹 (tuī xīn zhì fù)

- Meaning: To push one's heart and place one's intestines.
- Explanation: This idiom expresses complete sincerity and trust between friends or close associates, indicating openness and transparency in sharing thoughts and feelings.

同甘共苦 (tóng gān gòng kǔ)

- Meaning: To share weal and woe together.
- Explanation: It describes sharing joys and hardships with others, emphasising mutual support and solidarity in facing challenges or enjoying successes together.

知恩图报 (zhī ēn tú bào)

- Meaning: To remember kindness and repay it.
- Explanation: This idiom underscores the virtue of gratitude and the obligation to repay the kindness received, promoting harmonious relationships through reciprocal acts of goodwill.

信口开河 (xìn kǒu kāi hé)

- Meaning: To talk nonsense; to speak recklessly.
- Explanation: It refers to speaking without thinking carefully, potentially leading to misunderstandings or disruptions in communication, highlighting the importance of thoughtful speech in maintaining harmony.

言传身教 (yán chuán shēn jiào)

- Meaning: To teach by words and example.
- Explanation: This idiom emphasises the influence of both verbal instruction and personal actions in guiding others, promoting effective communication and positive role modelling in interpersonal relationships.

About Work or Business

Here are five Chinese idioms about work or business:

井井有条 (jǐng jǐng yǒu tiáo)

- Meaning: In good order; methodically arranged.
- Explanation: This idiom describes a situation where everything is well-organised and efficient, highlighting the importance of systematic planning and execution in achieving goals.

劳而无果 (lǎo ér wú guǒ)

- Meaning: To toil without achieving results.
- Explanation: It indicates working hard but failing to achieve the desired outcome, underscoring the importance of effective strategies and perseverance in work or business endeavours.

卧虎藏龙 (wò hǔ cáng lóng)

- Meaning: Hidden dragons and crouching tigers.
- Explanation: This idiom refers to hidden talents or formidable individuals who are not yet fully recognised or utilised, suggesting the presence of unexpected competition or challenges in business.

言而有信 (yán ér yǒu xìn)

- Meaning: To keep one's promise; to be true to one's word.
- Explanation: This idiom emphasises the importance of trustworthiness and integrity in business dealings, promoting reliability and credibility in professional relationships.

和气生财 (hé qì shēng cái)

- Meaning: Harmony brings wealth.
- Explanation: It suggests that maintaining harmonious relationships and a positive atmosphere in business interactions can lead to prosperity and success, emphasising the value of cooperation and goodwill.

About Emotions & Feelings

Here are five Chinese idioms about emotions and feelings:

喜怒哀乐 (xī nù ài lè)

- Meaning: Joy, anger, sorrow, and happiness.
- Explanation: This idiom encompasses a range of human emotions, highlighting the complexity and diversity of feelings experienced in life.

悲欢离合 (bēi huān lí hé)

- Meaning: Sorrow and joy; parting and reunion.
- Explanation: It describes life's ups and downs, including moments of sadness and happiness and occasions of separation and reunion.

同病相怜 (tóng bìng xiāng lián)

- Meaning: To sympathise with each other due to sharing similar experiences.
- Explanation: This idiom expresses empathy towards others going through similar difficulties or hardships, fostering understanding and compassion.

情同手足 (qíng tóng shǒu zú)

- Meaning: Relationship as close as brothers.
- Explanation: It describes a deep emotional bond between individuals, likening their relationship to that of brothers who share a strong camaraderie and mutual support.

情深意重 (qíng shēn yì zhòng)

- Meaning: Deep affection and profound meaning.
- Explanation: This idiom indicates intense emotions and significant sentiments attached to a relationship or a matter, highlighting the depth of feelings involved.

About Nature & The World

Here are five Chinese idioms about nature and the world:

云淡风轻 (yún dàn fēng qīng)

- Meaning: Light clouds and gentle breeze.
- Explanation: This idiom describes a serene atmosphere, often used to depict a peaceful and calm state of mind or situation.

水到渠成 (shuǐ dào qú chéng)

- Meaning: Water flows to the lowest point; things naturally fall into place.
- Explanation: It signifies that with persistence and patience, things will eventually succeed or reach their intended outcome, likening it to water flowing to its destination.

山高水长 (shān gāo shuǐ cháng)

- Meaning: High mountains and long rivers.
- Explanation: This idiom refers to vast and magnificent natural landscapes, often metaphorically describing enduring or profound characteristics.

秋高气爽 (qiū gāo qì shuǎng)

- Meaning: High autumn skies and refreshing air.
- Explanation: It describes autumn's pleasant weather, symbolising a refreshing and invigorating atmosphere, often used to depict a comfortable and enjoyable environment.

枝繁叶茂 (zhī fán yè mào)

- Meaning: Luxuriant branches and leaves.
- Explanation: This idiom refers to lush foliage and vigorous growth, used metaphorically to describe prosperity, abundance, or flourishing conditions.

Funny Chinese Idioms

Here are five humorous or quirky Chinese idioms, along with their cultural context and wordplay:

画蛇添足 (huà shé tiān zú)

- Meaning: Drawing a snake and adding legs.
- Explanation: This idiom humorously describes the unnecessary addition of something excessive or doing extra work that diminishes the original quality. In Chinese culture, snakes are traditionally depicted as powerful and agile creatures, so adding legs to a snake would be unnecessary and nonsensical.

对牛弹琴 (duì niú tán qín)

- Meaning: Playing the lute to a cow.
- Explanation: This idiom refers to explaining or discussing something with someone who cannot understand or appreciate it due to their lack of knowledge or comprehension. It humorously highlights the absurdity of communicating complex ideas to someone wholly unqualified or indifferent.

煞有介事 (shà yǒu jiè shì)

- Meaning: Act as if something is significant.
- Explanation: This idiom describes someone who exaggerates or pretends something trivial is extremely serious or significant. It plays on making a big deal out of nothing, adding humour to situations where someone blows things out of proportion.

半斤八两 (bàn jīn bā liǎng)

- Meaning: Six of one, half a dozen of the other.
- Explanation: This idiom means two things are equal or similar in quality, quantity, or outcome. It uses a quirky way of quantifying things (half a catty and eight taels, traditional Chinese units of weight), adding a humorous flair to expressing equivalence.

豁出去了 (huō chū qù le)

- Meaning: To go all out; to do something without regard to consequences.
- Explanation: This idiom humorously conveys the idea of taking extreme measures or making a bold decision without considering the risks or consequences. It reflects a daring and sometimes reckless attitude towards pursuing a goal.

Chinese idioms often reflect cultural values, historical anecdotes, or philosophical insights. The humour in these idioms usually arises from their vivid imagery or unexpected twists in meaning. Learning these idioms can be both entertaining and insightful.

By understanding the cultural context and wordplay behind each idiom, learners grasp the literal meaning and appreciate the creativity and wit embedded in the Chinese language. Associating each idiom with its humorous context helps make the learning process more engaging and memorable, encouraging deeper exploration into Chinese culture and language.

When and How to Use Chinese Idioms

Using Chinese idioms effectively involves understanding their literal and figurative meaning and the appropriate contexts for their usage in conversation and writing.

Appropriate Contexts for Using Idioms:

- Formal Writing:** Idioms are often used in formal writing, such as essays, articles, or speeches, to convey complex ideas or add literary flair. They can demonstrate a deep understanding of Chinese culture and language.
- Informal Expression:** In casual conversations with friends, family, or colleagues, idioms can add colour and expressiveness. However, be mindful of the audience's familiarity with the idiom to ensure effective communication.
- Literary or Artistic Works:** Idioms are commonly used in literature, poetry, and art to evoke imagery and convey themes. They contribute to the richness of artistic expression.
- Cultural Contexts:** Idioms often carry cultural connotations, so using them appropriately in contexts related to Chinese traditions, history, or folklore enhances understanding and appreciation.

Tips for Avoiding Misuse or Unnatural Usage:

- Understand the Context:** Ensure the idiom fits naturally into your conversation or writing context. Using an idiom can lead to clarity and unintended meanings.
- Know the Audience:** Consider the familiarity of your audience with the idiom. Avoid using obscure or outdated idioms that others may not easily understand.
- Use Idioms Sparingly:** Overusing idioms can make your speech or writing sound contrived or unnatural. Use them selectively to highlight critical points or add emphasis.
- Learn Proper Usage:** Study examples of native speakers using idioms in various contexts. This helps in understanding the nuances of their usage and improves fluency.

Practice Exercises:

To practice using Chinese idioms effectively, try the following exercises:

Create Sentences: Write sentences that incorporate specific idioms. For example:

- Idiom: 一箭两得 (yī jiǎn liǎng dé) – Achieve two goals with one action.
- Sentence: 我们应该通过环保活动，一箭两得地减少污染并提高公众意识。(We should reduce pollution and raise public awareness through environmental activities, achieving two goals with one action.)

Role-playing: Practice using idioms in role-playing scenarios or mock conversations. This helps in applying idioms naturally in everyday interactions.

Contextual Usage: Write short paragraphs or dialogues using idioms appropriately according to the context. Share these with language partners or teachers for feedback.

Reflective Writing: Reflect on personal experiences or events using idioms to express emotions or lessons learned. This exercise helps in internalising idioms and understanding their deeper meanings.

History of Chinese Idioms

Chinese idioms, known as chengyu (成语), have a rich and extensive history deeply intertwined with Chinese language, culture, literature, and philosophy. These idioms play a significant role in modern communication, reflecting their enduring relevance and cultural significance.

Chinese idioms trace their origins back to ancient times, evolving over millennia alongside the development of the Chinese language itself. Many idioms have roots in classical Chinese literature, such as poetry and historical texts, dating back to the Zhou, Qin, Han, and Tang dynasties. They were often derived from famous quotes, historical events, or philosophical musings of prominent scholars and thinkers.

During the imperial eras, idioms were used extensively in bureaucratic writings and examinations, where knowledge of classical texts and idiomatic expressions was highly valued. This institutionalisation helped solidify the idioms' importance in formal communication and education.

Chinese idioms are integral to the expression of complex ideas concisely and memorably. They encapsulate cultural values, moral principles, and social norms, making them powerful tools for communication and reflection.

Modern Chinese idioms remain prevalent in everyday conversations, formal speeches, literature, media, and educational settings. They serve as a cultural bond, connecting generations through shared knowledge and understanding of traditional wisdom and historical contexts.

Conclusions

If you are interested in learning the Chinese history, then one way to do so is by exploring Chengyu and ask your Chinese friends or teachers to help you understand its roots and know interesting stories behind it.

Exploring Chinese idioms offers a unique glimpse into the depths of Chinese civilisation and enhances language learning by connecting learners to cultural heritage. For those who want to know more, join a class in Singapore with [LindaMandarin](#) to learn Chinese language and idioms.